Emily McKay

London, UK | e.k.mckay@lse.ac.uk | linkedin.com/in/emily-mckay-a22034288 | github.com/emckay2028

PROFILE

Data Science for Political Science undergraduate (American University) on the LSE General Course, 2026–27. Self-proposed a cross-national study of democratic erosion that won its session at AU's 2026 Undergraduate Research Symposium. Turns V-Dem, DEED, FARA and GSS data into reproducible R analyses and research papers.

EDUCATION

London School of Economics and Political Science – General Course Sep 2026 – Jun 2027

- Modules: AN100 Being Human: Contemporary Themes in Social Anthropology; GV263 Public Policy Analysis; MY 202A Machine Learning for Social Scientists; GY 204 Political Geography; G264 Politics and Institutions in Europe

American University, Washington, DC – BS Data Science for Political Science 2024–2028 (exp.)

- Relevant coursework: Data Science for Political Science (DATA-412); Intermediate Statistics; Linear Algebra; Politics in the Developing World; American Political Parties; Research for Political Science; Public Policy Analysis
- Award: American University Undergraduate Research Award winner, Justice, Equality & Power, AU Undergraduate Research Symposium, Apr 2026.

SELECTED POLICY AND RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Who Erodes Democracy? Actor-Level Evidence from a Two-Part Model of Authoritarian Behaviour

Award-Winning Independent Research, American University (faculty mentor: Prof. Popova) Dec 2025 – Jun 2026

- Proposed an original question – whose authoritarian actions predict democratic decline? – and built a new country-year dataset merging DEED v7 events with V-Dem v15, going beyond the course brief.
- Estimated lagged two-part fixed-effects panel models in R (fixest) on 149 countries and 2,930 country-years (2000–2023), separating the onset from the escalation of authoritarian acts across seven actor types.
- Tested robustness (Liberal Democracy Index, alternative lags, dropping event-heavy countries, clustered errors); presented to a mixed-discipline panel and revised the Quarto manuscript towards journal submission.

Foreign Lobbying and Regime Type: FARA and V-Dem Apr 2026 – May 2026

Group project (3 students), Data Science for Political Science (DATA-412), American University

- Investigated whether regime type and democratic backsliding predict foreign-government lobbying in the US by merging US Department of Justice FARA filings with V-Dem democracy scores in R.
- Identified and corrected an aggregation error that assigned registered agents to a single year, restoring an accurate country-year panel.
- Led the modelling section of the Quarto report (log, GDP-adjusted regressions; democracy-by-time interaction), reporting a null interaction result transparently with residual diagnostics.

Reproductive Infrastructure and Abortion Attitudes in the US Mar 2026 – Apr 2026

Group research paper, Research for Political Science, American University

- Developed a theoretical argument and formal hypothesis, grounded in a literature review, linking support for sex education, contraception access and health and childcare spending to abortion attitudes.
- Analysed GSS 2024 data using multiple regression with economic, ideological and demographic controls; support for sex education and teen access to the pill was significantly associated with support for abortion for any reason.
- Wrote up limitations (social-desirability bias, binary outcome) and presented results with publication-style regression tables (R, gt).

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Supplemental Instruction Leader, Intermediate Statistics (STAT-302), American University Aug 2025 – May 2026

- Led weekly peer study sessions and wrote practice tests on t-tests, ANOVA and log transformation.

Hostess, Snooze, an A.M. Eatery, Houston, TX Apr 2025 – Aug 2025

- Seated an average of 350 guests per shift; earlier café and retail customer-service roles (Purple Kow, Deniss Mills).

TECHNICAL AND RESEARCH SKILLS

Methods: fixed-effects panel and two-part models; OLS and interaction models; t-tests, ANOVA, chi-squared tests
Software: R (fixest, dplyr, ggplot2, gt), Quarto, RStudio, Git/GitHub; Python (pandas, Jupyter; working knowledge)
Data: V-Dem, Democratic Erosion Event Dataset (DEED), DOJ FARA, General Social Survey (GSS)
Research and writing: literature reviews, theory and hypothesis development, research papers, presentations